NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠3

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠K

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J 4 ♥ A K 7 ♦ 10 7 4 2 ♣ K J 3	
♠ 10 9 6 3 ♥ 9 3 ♦ K 5 ♣ 10 9 8 4 2	N W E S	♠ Q 7 5 ♥ Q J 10 8 5 2 ♦ A 3 ♣ Q 5
	♠ K 8 2 ♥ 6 4 ♦ Q J 9 8 6 ♣ A 7 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♥	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

Partner's 3♦ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game. While 5♦ is possibly the best contract your double ♥ stopper should sway you to 3NT instead. This is the old "9 tricks are easier than 11" principle.

North plays 3NT. As expected, East attacks in his ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

Even if West holds both black Queens, (not likely), you can only finesse your way to 8 tricks. Since you need 9 tricks you must establish the ♦ suit.

If East holds both the ♦A and ♦K then you are going down, because they will win the race to establish ♥s before you can establish ♦s.

But when the ♦A and ♦K are in different hands you have a good chance for success; it depends on West having no ♥ at the time he takes his ♦ winner.

So you should hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. If East started with 6 ♥s then West will be out. So whether he wins his ♦ trick first or second he still won't be able to continue ♥s.

After your hold up West has no ♥s. If he takes the first ♦ trick he will have to lead another suit. You will still have a ♥ stopper for when East wins **HIS** ♦ trick.

On the other hand, if East takes the first ♦ trick he can certainly drive out your last ♥ stopper. But then, when West takes **HIS** ♦ winner he will have no ♥.

Finally, if East had only a 5-card ♥ suit, good defense would beat you. But they have to be sure West wins the first ♦ trick, and they might slip up.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 7 4 ♥ K 10 4 2 ♦ J 9 7 4 ♣ Q J	
♠ K 5 ♥ J 7 5 3 ♦ Q 6 2 ♣ 8 5 4 2	N W E S	♠ J 9 6 ♥ A 8 ♦ A K 10 5 3 ♣ A K 6
	♠ Q 10 8 3 2 ♥ Q 9 6 ♦ 8 ♣ 10 9 7 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♦	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠3

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠3. Your first problem is which ♠ to play from dummy. That is an easy problem. If you play the ♠K you might lose the first five or six tricks. If you play low you guarantee a ♠ stopper. North plays the ♠A and returns the ♠7 to dummy's ♠K. South plays the ♠2 on this trick.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

You need 2 more winners, and you need to get them before you lose the lead because it appears that South can cash 3 more ♠ tricks.

That means you need all 5 ♦ tricks. The good news is that the 5 missing ♦s will split 3-2 about two-thirds of the time. The bad news is that they will be 4-1 about one-third of the time. Can you protect yourself against a 4-1 break?

Maybe and maybe not. If South has ♦ J x x x there won't be anything you can do about it. But if North has this holding then you can succeed if you play your cards right.

*Did you like that "play your cards right" quip?*First play a ♦ to your ♦K; both defenders follow. Next play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q. South discards a ♣. You are conveniently in dummy so you play dummy's last ♦ and North's ♦ J 9 are caught in a pincer movement by your ♦ A 10 5.

It was important to play the ♦s exactly as described because dummy had only one entry left, the ♦Q.

Suppose your first ♦ play had been dummy's ♦Q. You could make your contract if you play a small ♦ and finesse the ♦10. But at that point you wouldn't know whether the ♦s were splitting evenly or not. You'd be risking defeat on a hand where everybody who played for the 3-2 split was making the contract.

By taking the **SECOND** ♦ trick with dummy's ♦Q the 4-1 split is exposed at the right time.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 4 ♥ J 10 9 7 3 ♦ 6 4 2 ♣ K J 5	
♠ Q J 10 5 2 ♥ 8 4 ♦ J 8 3 ♣ Q 9 6	N W E S	♠ 9 7 ♥ K 6 5 2 ♦ K Q 9 ♣ 10 7 4 2
	♠ A K 6 3 ♥ A Q ♦ A 10 7 5 ♣ A 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	3♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠Q

Partner's 3♦ bid is a transfer; you dutifully reply 3♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner has just a 5-card ♥ suit. He doesn't have 4 ♠s or he would have used Stayman.

With no 8-card Major fit you pass 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q on which East plays the ♠7.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

You might get one more winner from the ♣ finesse, but basically you are going to have to establish dummy's ♥s.

You don't have the entries to think about going over to dummy to finesse the ♥K, so you play the ♥A then the ♥Q, hoping a defender will grab their ♥K

and set up three ♥ winners in dummy.

But they allow your ♥Q to hold the trick.

Now you are desperate. You need two entries to dummy, one so you can play ♥s to force out the ♥Q, and another to enjoy the good ♥s. One of these entries will be the ♣K and the second will have to be the ♣J. So you play a ♣ to the Jack and then you . . .

. . .

Lucky you. West held the ♣Q.

But don't get too smug. A lot of the plays work in these practice deals because they are set up to reward the correct Plan. In real life finesses only work half the time.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 10 7 ♥ K 9 8 2 ♦ J 10 8 2 ♣ Q 10	
♠ A J 5 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A K 7 3 ♣ A J 4 2	N W E S	♠ 6 4 2 ♥ A Q J 10 6 3 ♦ 5 4 ♣ 7 3
	♠ K 9 8 3 ♥ 4 ♦ Q 9 6 ♣ K 9 8 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♦	Pass
2♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♦J

You have 9 points, an invitational strength hand. With 6 ♥s you transfer partner by bidding 2♦. Partner replies 2♥.

You have 9 points, an invitational strength hand. With 6 ♥s you transfer partner by bidding 2♦. Partner replies 2♥.

Remember, you have invitational strength, so even with a great trump suit you bid just 3♥. Partner puts it in game at 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by East.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♦J and South plays the ♦9.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4Losers are as seen from dummy, the long-trump hand.

You might get lucky in one of the black suits, but your best hope is that North holds the ♥K.

You win the first ♦ and play a ♥ to dummy's ♥10, which wins the trick. You smile. Return to your hand with the other ♦, then play your last ♥ to dummy's ♥J, which wins the trick. But this time you don't smile because South discards! North still holds ♥ K 9 and you have no more ♥s to lead for a finesse. Does that finish you?

Never say die. Return to your hand with a black Ace and ruff a ♦ in dummy. Dummy's trumps are now ♥ A Q 6 and North still has ♥ K 9.

Back to your hand with the other black Ace and ruff another ♦ in dummy. Dummy's trumps are now ♥ A Q and North still has ♥ K 9. Play any black card from dummy, then sit back and wait for your two trump tricks!

Bad trump splits can sometimes be countered by a technique called a trump coup.

The coup is accomplished by ruffing to shorten the trump holding so you won't have to play trumps from that holding.

Pretty much like this hand.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ J 9 7
♥ A 5
♦ A K J 10 3
♣ A K 6

♠ 8 5 2
♥ J 10 4
♦ 9 6 2
♣ Q 10 9 4



♠ K Q 10 4
♥ 9 8 6 2
♦ 5 4
♣ 8 5 3

♠ A 6 3
♥ K Q 7 3
♦ Q 8 7
♣ J 7 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	4NT
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♠K

Because of his 3-4-3-3 distribution, partner chose not to look for a ♥ fit. If he had opted for Stayman the contract would have turned out the same. The 4NT response is quantitative, inviting you to bid 6NT if you have a maximum.

You do. 6NT.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♠K. You will have to make an early decision on whether to hold up or not.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 5 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 11

Only one more winner is needed. You should play a low ♠ from dummy in the hope that East will lead the suit again, giving you a trick with your ♠J (you know East holds ♠Q). In fact, you should even give him some incentive to play another ♠ by dropping your ♠9, pretending to hold just the ♠ J 9. But East noticed his partner's discouraging ♠2 and switched to the ♣8.

You try the ♣J but West plays the ♣Q and you have to win with your ♣K.

Your chances for success are slipping away and you are down to your last hope. Your ♠J is a threat that only East can guard against. If East also is the defender with long ♥s then he would also have to guard dummy's fourth ♥. In that case you could squeeze him. But there is one important play you must make for the squeeze to function.

You must play dummy's ♠A to unblock so your ♠J can be the threat you need. Then play the ♥A, ♣A and 5 ♦ winners.

If East has thrown the ♠Q you win your ♠J and dummy's two high ♥s. But since he probably held onto the ♠Q you just play a ♥ to dummy and hope all three ♥s are winners.

Since East had to guard both the ♥s and your ♠J, he was unable to do both, and the squeeze worked.

You were lucky it wasn't West with the 4 ♥s.